Geography of the Heart

By Fenton Johnson

On a summer evening, not long after Larry and I moved in together, when he was at his healthiest, and it was possible to believe that we would be given two or six or ten years together with the aging cat, we sat on the deck not long before sunset, watching fog peer over the hills. The moon, thinnest of Arabian crescents, was descending into the wired red cage of the radio tower that squats on Twin Peaks. Larry brought out the camera - he wanted to send his parents pictures of the view from the new apartment.

INTRODUCTION

It is the story of two men: Larry, who has AIDS, and his partner, who does not. It is the story of a healthy man who freely loves an HIV positive man, knowing that he will inevitably have to usher him through to death. But through the pain and injustice of this disease, we learn how, in the end, love allows us to continue, even after death. Geography of the Heart, by Fenton Johnson.

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He took photos of the view, then we clowned for each other in front of the camera - more pictures for the overflowing box that now sits at one end of my desk.

Afterward we wrapped ourselves in blankets and watched as the moon freed itself of the radio tower and sank into the fog. We talked a little about this and that - nothing important; end-of-the-day partner talk. I wasn't paying much attention. I was thinking about all kinds of pressing matters - work – deadlines. Somewhere in the middle of my thoughts he spoke up and said something like this: "Love is like a ripe peach. You take it when and where you find it, there's no point in letting it sit around. If you're lucky enough to come across it, you'd better enjoy it right there."

Later that summer, when he grew really, evidently, seriously ill, I thought, as little as possible but inevitably, of what would become of me after he died. I figured, of course, that a relatively young person who'd lost a great love would have a chance at such love again – after all, that would be only fair.

Then Larry died, and time and more time passed, and I came to understand how fairness has nothing to do with how and when love arrives; that I can be grateful for love only when and while it's happening, when it's quite literally in the hand.

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The last day, the first day.

No sleep.

In the middle of the night I phoned and reached Larry's doctor in his San Francisco office, just as he was leaving for the day. His first question: "How could you let him get that sick?"

The next morning I carried Larry to the car. In the car: accelerator to the floor. Five hours to Paris. Larry slept. At a stop for gas he tried to use the bathroom but was too weak to stand. In Paris: lost, then boxed in a blocked one-way street. Sidewalk driving: bad directions.

At the American Hospital: I couldn't locate the emergency entrance. I parked at the main door, left Larry in the car, and dashed up the stairs. *"Mon copain est gravement malade avec le SIDA."* (My friend is gravely ill with AIDS). My words echoed in the small waiting area, or was it just my imagination. *"S'il vous plait madame, je vous prie!"* I was begging now. The silent watching waiting room. The receptionist called for emergency staff. Attendants came with a wheelchair and got Larry from the car. The receptionist pushed forms at us. Larry tendered his credit card and signed his name forming each letter with precision and care on a slip of paper whose carbon sits before me now, years later – his last signature.

The doctors: "Tout va bien" (everything is fine) IV's, private room, then the move to intensive care, waiting. Late in the evening I returned the car to the rental lot at deGaulle, then spent the night in Larry's friend's apartment.

No Sleep.

Next day: I phoned early. The intensive care unit's head nurse: "Monsieur Rose se repose. Tout va bien." (Mr. Rose is resting. Everything is fine.) Later I would discover that he had had a heart attack in the middle of

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the night – that he'd died and been revived. Visiting hours would begin at 2:15. I paced the apartment- might as well be at the hospital. I arrived there late morning and climbed the stairs to the intensive care ward. Entrée Interdite (Entry Forbidden).

His bed was straight across from the ICU door. He saw me and struggled to sit up. He tried to say something about the night before. I made him lie down, put my finger to my lips. "They'll throw me out if they see me in here." *"Ne pleure pas." he said* – "Don't cry."

They saw me there. The head nurse, in forceful English ordered me to leave or she would call security. I left. I walked around an hour, two hours: *Je pleure.*

At exactly 2:15 I opened the ICU door. He was in the midst of a second heart attack. I saw the cardiac monitor rise, then fall, - the monitor alarm sounded – no one came. I stood frozen, watching, unbelieving, afraid to move for fear of being seen and thrown out. The monitor went dead, flatline.

No one came.

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I waited. I waited. The monitor cried, a harsh flat plaintive hum. Zero zero zero.

No one came.

I moved to embrace him, and in my crossing to his bed I was spotted by the nurses' station. A nurse moved towards me, then noticed the monitor's blaring hum. Several nurses pushed me aside and rushed to his bed. They began the violent dance of CPR. I backed from the room.

I had no need to witness this.

Five minutes, ten, fifteen minutes. The doctor emerged. "Il vit encore?" I asked, unable to speak in either language any form of the evil word.

"*Non. Il est mort. Je suis desole.*"

The walls fell away, the floor fell from under my feet, the doctor was no longer there. I was alone, as alone as it was possible to be, falling into a well so deep I didn't know how deep, falling. In this single moment, my youth fell away, I was no longer innocent, I was no longer young. I embraced all that I had been given and my arms closed on nothing. Now I was falling free, free

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falling, and as I fell, I thought of all those candles lit, all those wishes made—a painless death, a speedy death, a death with me at hand.

At the American hospital the nurses would not allow me to watch or help as they cleaned Larry after his death. I would not want to see him, they told me, in this state. And I acceded - did I have a choice? They had his body, on which I had no legal claim.

While I waited I thought, "I who have bathed his sores, wiped the sweat from his forehead, embraced him in passion and in need; I who have in some way risked my life to shepherd him to this death - I know his body as none of them know it: I want to know it once more, in the time of his death, but I'm denied this."

I am, after all, only his friend.

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A large grassy bank cradled in the oxbow bend of a river flowing through a deciduous place, curving past a hardwood forest of oak and hickory and walnut – the landscape of my childhood asserts itself, though here

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and there a redwood pierces the temperate forest's profile and the stream runs clear and gravel-bottomed.

I have lived many years in northern California.

The riverbank is populated with men, men who have loved me and whom I've loved, and men whom I've wanted to love; men I wanted to date but hadn't the courage or time to ask; men who rejected me, men whom I rejected; men I saw only once, on an airplane, in a bar, on a crowded bus, on a nearly empty beach, in a foreign land, in a classroom, in a church. Many of them are surely ill or dead, but they are all here, sons of the mothers of the world, alive and full of joy on the grassy bank of my heart, here at the cusp of their lives and somewhere in their midst sits Larry, *my* Larry. Young enough still to be beautiful, old enough to know the meaning of the coolness behind the sun's warmth; old enough to know that every shadow promises night; old enough to know death.

I cross the river to join them.

We are gathered by a river where we have knowledge of time out side of time, of death outside of death, and

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there on the grassy green bank of my east-west heart,

in the endless low-slanting sun, we give ourselves over to

making memory, and remembering.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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